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In spite of the deal size, Singh's is not the only such transaction in the past one year. In Kautilya Marg, at the heart of Delhi's Diplomatic Enclave, a ₹137-crore bungalow easily found a buyer, while the 25,000 sq. ft family home of iconic film director-cum-producer B.R. Chopra in Mumbai's Juhu fetched ₹183 crore in June. Much like Singh, his contemporary, actor Rajkummar Rao, too, bagged a 3,456-sq. ft triplex apartment in the posh Juhu area at ₹44 crore from co-actor Janhvi Kapoor. While these

are just a few instances of standalone properties grabbing attention due to their sheer scale, a closer look at the property market indicates that in spite of the pandemic and the economic uncertainties in recent times, demand for luxury real estate is booming.

According to Reeza Sebastian Karimpanal, President, Residential, Embassy Group, uber-luxury villas and plots in self-sustained communities where buyers can design homes are in high demand. "Modern homebuyers have more access to information than ever before, are well-read, well-travelled, and committed to the environment. With this upsurge in awareness, consumers are more conscious of the amenities and facilities they require when looking for a home that caters to a global lifestyle," says Karimpanal. She points out that earlier luxury homebuyers were primarily the ultra high net-worth individuals (UHNIs), high net-worth individuals (HNIs) and even non-resident Indians (NRIs). "However, in 2022, we anticipate a rise in the number of first-time homebuyers investing in luxury properties due to favourable interest rates and more disposable income," she says.

According to her, home loan interest rates—that remain below pre-pandemic levels despite recent hikes—and the phenomenon of work from home have played a role in developing buyers' affinity towards luxury homes. This has led realtors to offer homes that are more conducive to the 'live-work-play' lifestyle. Now, homebuyers are increasingly seeking larger homes with flexible layouts, designated work areas, more natural light and ventilation, outdoor spaces, and other features, such as lap pools that cater to their overall well-being. "NRI investments in Indian real estate hit an all-time high of \$13.1 billion in CY21 and may rise to \$14.9 billion in 2022. A substantial percentage of these NRIs make up India's international UHNI population, and about 55 per cent of those who own real estate in India will allocate their wealth towards buying a second home here," says Karimpanal. In India, residential properties priced above ₹8 crore are considered luxury, except for the Mumbai market, where ₹12 crore and above is the benchmark.

The demand for luxury homes and changing consumer preferences post-Covid-19 have also been noticed by Swaroop Anish, Executive Director at Prestige Group. After Covid-19, more homebuyers are now going for 5,000-6,000 sq. ft-homes that usually fall in the luxury category, he says. The Bengaluru-based real estate major has already launched some of the key projects in the city like Prestige Leela Residence and the Kingfisher towers, where a 4-BHK apartment may cost over ₹30 crore. To cater to the growing demand for such properties, it has launched projects in Mumbai, the largest market for luxury real estate. After successfully completing its Prestige City in Mulund, it is now eyeing two key luxury projects in Pali Hill and Marine Lines.

As per analysis by the real estate firm JLL India, the majority of locations in South Mumbai, such as Altamount Road, Cuffe Parade, Nana Chowk, Nepean Sea Road, among others, are predominantly luxury markets, with bungalows or apartments priced upwards of ₹12 crore. "The most preferred micro-market in the National Capital Region for high-end properties are South and Central Delhi, with tra-